fd / fdfind cheatsheet

Find files and directories **by name**. To search file contents, use `rg`.

Verified against local `fdfind 9.0.0` help on 2026-10-20 (UTC).

Command name and syntax

Ubuntu/Debian commonly install this tool as `fdfind`; other systems use `fd`. All examples below use `fdfind`. Substitute `fd` if that is your executable.

```
fdfind [OPTIONS] [PATTERN] [SEARCH_ROOT ...]
fdfind                        # List entries below
the current directory
fdfind invoice ./documents    # Names containing
invoice
fdfind '' ./documents         # All eligible entries
under this root
```

By default: recursive search, regular expression patterns, matching against the basename, and smart case (case-insensitive unless the pattern contains uppercase). Hidden entries and ignored entries are skipped. Git ignore rules normally require a Git repository. Quote patterns to prevent shell expansion.

Important switches

Switch	Purpose
`-g`, `--glob`	Use a glob instead of a regex; useful for exact filenames.
`-F`, `--fixed-strings`	Literal substring search, rather than regex.
`-s`, `--case-sensitive`	Force case-sensitive matching.
`-i`, `--ignore-case`	Force case-insensitive matching.
`-p`, `--full-path`	Match the full absolute path instead of just the basename.
`-H`, `--hidden`	Include hidden entries; ignore rules still apply.
`-I`, `--no-ignore`	Disable ignore rules; hidden entries still need `-H`.
`-u`, `--unrestricted`	Include hidden and ignored entries (`-H -I`).
`-E GLOB`, `--exclude GLOB`	Exclude matching entries; repeatable.
`-t TYPE`, `--type TYPE`	Filter by entry type; see below.
`-e EXT`, `--extension EXT`	Filter extensions without a leading dot; repeatable.
`-d N`, `--max-depth N`	Limit traversal depth; 1 searches immediate children.
`--min-depth N`, `--exact-depth N`	Restrict result depth.
`-S SIZE`, `--size SIZE`	Filter file size; + means at least, - at most, neither means exact.
`--changed-within TIME`	Modification time newer than a date or duration.
`--changed-before TIME`	Modification time older than a date or duration.
`-o USER:GROUP`, `--owner USER:GROUP`	Filter owner/group; either side can be omitted.
`-L`, `--follow`	Traverse symlinked directories.
`--one-file-system`	Do not descend into another filesystem.
`-a`, `--absolute-path`	Print absolute paths.
`-l`, `--list-details`	Detailed listing similar to `ls -l`.
`-0`, `--print0`	NUL-delimit paths for filename-safe pipelines.
`-x CMD`, `--exec CMD`	Run a command for each result, in parallel by default.
`-X CMD`, `--exec-batch CMD`	Pass results together to a command; OS limits can split batches.
`-j N`, `--threads N`	Set search/execution threads; 1 makes `-x` sequential.
`--max-results N`, `-1`	Stop after N results, or after one result.
`-q`, `--quiet`	Print nothing; status 0 if a result exists, 1 if none.
`--show-errors`	Display filesystem traversal errors.
`--color never`	Disable color for saved output.
`-h`, `--help`, `-V`, `--version`	Short help, detailed help, version.

Types: `f` file, `d` directory, `l` symlink, `x` executable file, `e` empty file/directory, `s` socket, `p` named pipe, `b` block device, `c` character device. Use `-t e -t f` for empty files or `-t e -t d` for empty directories.

Practical examples

```
# Regex: exact filename, or alternative extensions
fdfind '^report\.csv$' ./documents
fdfind '\.(csv|json)$' ./exports

# Glob: exact name or wildcard
fdfind -g 'README.md' .
fdfind -g '*.log' ./logs

# Literal text containing regex metacharacters
fdfind -F 'report[final]' ./documents

# Files with either extension; directories; symlinks;
empty files
fdfind -t f -e jpg -e png ./images
fdfind -t d -g '*cache*' .
fdfind -t l .
fdfind -t e -t f .

# Include hidden entries; ignore rules still apply
fdfind -H -t f -g '.env*' .

# Include ignored entries; hidden entries are still
excluded
fdfind -I -t f -e log .

# Include both hidden and ignored entries (-H -I is
equivalent to -u)
fdfind -H -I -t f -g '.env*' .

# Include hidden and ignored entries, excluding
selected directories
fdfind -u -t f -E .git -E node_modules -e log .

# Match directory components too
fdfind -p -g '**/config/*.json' .

# Immediate children only
fdfind -d 1 -t f '' ./documents

# Size range: at least 10 MiB and at most 100 MiB
fdfind -t f -S +10mi -S -100mi ./exports

# Modified within 24 hours (relative to command
execution)
TZ=UTC fdfind -t f --changed-within 1d ./logs

# Modification times strictly after/before these UTC
boundaries
TZ=UTC fdfind -t f --changed-within '2026-10-01
00:00:00' \
  --changed-before '2026-10-02 00:00:00' ./logs

# Owner or group
fdfind -t f --owner root ./exports
fdfind -t f --owner :analysts ./exports

# Read-only commands on results; put -x/-X last
```

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```
fdfind -t f -e log ./logs -j 1 -x sha256sum -- '{}'
fdfind -t f -e txt ./documents -X wc -l -- '{}'

# Filename-safe pipeline (GNU xargs: -r skips
execution when input is empty)
fdfind -t f -e log -0 ./logs | xargs -0 -r sha256sum
--

# Pattern beginning with a dash
fdfind -- '-backup' ./documents

# Save a sorted list; create ./reports first if
needed
fdfind -a -t f --color never ./documents | LC_ALL=C
sort > ./reports/file-list.txt
```

Execution placeholders and common pitfalls

Placeholder	Expansion
`{}`	Path
`{/}`	Basename
`{//}`	Parent directory
`{.}`	Path without extension
`{/.}`	Basename without extension

- A bare pattern is a regex: `.` means any character; use `\.` for a literal dot.
- `-e log` selects extensions; it does not search file contents.
- `-x` executes programs directly. Shell pipelines/redirection require an explicit shell.
- Search and execution order are not guaranteed. Use NUL-aware sorting for filenames containing newlines (`sort -z`); line-based sorting is for ordinary filenames.
- Size units: `k/m/g` are decimal; `ki/mi/gi` are binary.
- Date filters use **modification time**, not creation time. Set `TZ=UTC` for UTC date interpretation.
- For evidence, search a read-only mount and use read-only child commands; `-x`/`-X` can run any program, including modifying ones.

Reference used: local `fdfind --help`. Upstream: https://github.com/sharkdp/fd.

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